Unit 1 - Communication and Employability in IT
Assignment 6

M3 - Explain how an awareness of learning style can aid personal development

Task description: *Using the results of your learning style test (see link in resources below). Write a report that explains how knowing your learning style can make your learning more effective.*

A report that shows your understanding of yours and others people's learning styles

A learning style is basically an individual's natural or habitual pattern of acquiring and processing information in learning situation. There are commonly 3 types of learning styles, they are: visual, auditory and kinaesthetic.

Individuals with an auditory learning style take in information through listening. There are certain learning techniques for auditory such as rhymes, rhythms or reading the work aloud several times to help memorise important information. These type of learners tend to study in a very quiet environment so they can understand what they are hearing a lot more clearly.

Individuals with a visual learning style tend to learn information with what they see. They learn from pictures and learn best from visual visual displays including: diagrams, illustrated text book, videos, flip charts, use of interactive whiteboards and handouts.

Individuals with a kinaesthetic style of learning means that they use their body and sense of touch to learn about the world around them. They tend to find it hard to sit still for long periods of time and get distracted by many things. Kinaesthetic learners usually take frequent study breaks to move around to learn new things such as playing and fidgeting with items around them.

Explanations of how knowing about different learning styles can help your development

Now that I have learned and have a good amount of knowledge to figure out what my learning style is, I will need to know how much this can benefit me in my personal development.

With the earlier information about the different types of learner styles, I did a test on my learning style to find out whether I am a visual learner, auditory learner or a kinaesthetic. The image below is the image that was generated after the test.

The scores are out of 20 for each style. A score of 20 indicates the style is used often.

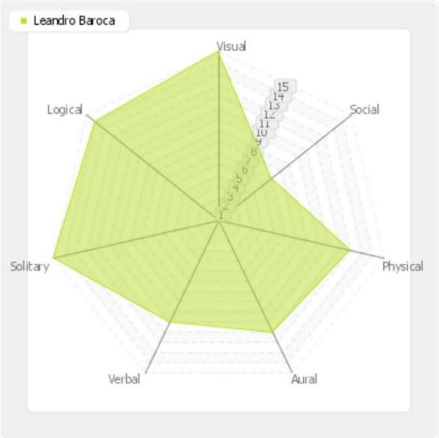
Style Scores

Visual	15
Social	6
Physical	12
Aural	11
Verbal	10
Solitary	15
Logical	14

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Learning Styles Graph



As it shows in the statistics of the test, it says that I am mostly a visual learner out of the visual, verbal, aural and logical and physical learning types. However, logical does come in close. Out of Solitary and Social learning style I got a 15 out of 15 with solitary. I can confirm that this is an accurate statistic due to me personally not enjoying company when I am working or learning.

In conclusion, I have learned what the 3 main learning styles are and what they mean. Also, I have been able to analyse my own learning style and the way that I learn by doing a test myself. I figured out that my learning style is a visual learning style, so now I can use this to my advantage in the future when learning or working on a new topic.

However, I should now know how to help myself develop the way I behave around other people, in particular the amount of different people around me, and being able to communicate effectively and efficiently with people are physically unequal to others, such as visual impaired people, so that I can give and receive the respect with my personal development.

D2 - Review progress on a personal development plan, identifying areas for improvement

Task description: *You will need to write a review of your personal development plan, your review should detail what went well and also what you would do differently next time:*

A review of your self-assessment about your personal strengths and areas for improvement

Since I have created a new and improved personal development plan, I have had the opportunity to find my newer or hidden weaknesses and overcome them by setting new goals. In this review I will be stating what I have accomplished in the time that has passed.

Assessing your own strengths

The positive consequences of knowing my strengths is so I can find out what I am good at, and it will allow me to save time on having to re-learn a skill or job. Especially when I am trying to study or check out future career options, knowing which talents and skills I personally have will help me narrow down my choices the right way.

The negative consequences of knowing my strengths is that I might know so many strengths and think that I and really good at one particular in some situations, that I may become too confident within that particular situation.

For example, suppose that I was good at programming within college, and I get given a programming assignment. I may think that I might be really good at the subject so I leave the assignment to the last minute, which I then realise the amount of work I need to do within that short amount of time and the assignment is filled with many bits of information that I have not yet encountered.

Not only would this decrease my confidence greatly, it would also bring an overwhelming amount of stress and anxiety which makes it very hard to actually carry on with the assignment. Which would cause the deadline to be passed without handing in the work, causing me to fail that assignment and subject.

The way I can improve on this area is by not getting so confident with a particular strength. What I mean by this is to not be so confident to a point of where I leave it for the last minute thinking I can do it and then lates realise how I did not know how much work or how hard it really was.

Which can cause consequences that will not only have an effect on my life at the moment, but also my future life and employment.

<u>Assessing your own area for improvement</u>

The positive consequences of knowing my areas of improvement is so that I can acknowledge something that I'm not particularly proud of, I empower myself to be more responsible. It's impossible to deal with the weaknesses if I refuse to acknowledge that they are there.

Furthermore, when I deny that an emotion, habit or problem exists, it tends to come up at inconvenient times, causing me to feel powerless and out of control. Conversely, if I acknowledge that a weakness exists, I can avoid putting myself in situation where I act out that weakness. Also, I will have more control over my own behaviour in all situations.

For example, suppose I have a tendency to be too lazy way too much at holiday time. If I am ashamed of this perceived weakness and try to pretend it doesn't exist, I'll find yourself going back to work and being too lazy when there are a lot of deadlines and end up slacking off too

much. This would cause much more problems, which can cause an overwhelming amount of stress and greatly improve the weakness.

Instead, if I acknowledge to myself that this is a weakness, I can decide whether or not to actually be motivated to do the work and come up with strategies on how to cut out the amount of work I do per burst.

The negative consequences of knowing my areas of improvement is that I might think that I am way too weak in this certain area that I believe that it would be impossible to be improved.

For example, I may be very weak in one of the subjects in the IT course that I will believe that I will have no way of actually improving it. This means that I would do little to no work for each assignment because I will feel frustrated and stressed because I would of been deluded at the fact that it would be impossible to improve on this causing myself not to do well on the subject.

When, in reality, there was all the possibility of actually improving on this subject if I tried hard enough. Furthermore, if I do later realise that my weakness in this area has been improved, I will immediately regret the fact that I didn't try hard enough on the subject.

The way I can improve on this area is by being determined and believing that it is possible to improve on most weaknesses, especially when to do with education. Sometimes it might be the fact that it would be much harder for me to learn the subject what compared to everyone else, when it is actually fine because some people have different learning speeds.

<u>An evaluation of the target setting process, including long, medium and short-term targets</u>

<u>Setting a Long Term Goal</u>

The positive consequences of setting long-term goals is that I can plan my future career and the type of employment that I can get if I follow the plan accordingly. Long-term goals also eliminates distractions if the goal is made and followed accordingly, unless that distraction is ignored or not thought through with the consequences.

What I mean by this is that a long-term goals can help me ignore the distractions around me which will slow me down or even prevent me from reaching these long-term goals. For example, I might have a long-term goal that says I will apply and attend a university straight after college and I am hoping that I get accepted.

However, a couple of my friends tell me they are doing a gap year. This type of situation can go both ways depending on my responsibility. Say if I was responsible enough to say no because it's not part of my plan, then I do get accepted into a university with a course in which I've desired on doing, then all goes well.

The negative consequences of setting long-term goals is that it is very unreliable due to the large amount of time that is associated with a long-term goal. This may seem contradictory to my positive consequences, however it is true.

There is a chance that all the long-term planning may be for nothing with one significant error or with a bundle of errors. Even though it is still possible to fully follow a long-term goal, but that's if it's set in such a flawless way or that the goals that are involved aren't too hard to achieve.

As I mentioned before about long-term goals eliminating distractions, but only if I was responsible. They can also be caused from significant problems and events, causing the long-term goal to be broken and discontinued. The same can be said from a small event, which can cause a massive chain reaction which makes it grow into a significant problem.

For example, such as receiving a job application for a full time job or not getting the grade requirements for university Such as being more lazy with producing work or leaving the work at the last minute.

The way I can improve on this area is by being responsible with my long term goals and thinking through every decision to make sure that it goes accordingly with my goals. Usually, my goals are set for the benefit of my future and employment, so following my goals will be a responsible and a non-regretful move for my end.

Setting a Medium Term Goal

The positive consequences of setting medium-term goals is that it can give specific priorities, can have clear plans and can cause increased awareness.

Medium term goals are useful with clean plans because it can help me in what I want to achieve and how I will accomplish those achievements. For example, a life without goals is like a boat without a rudder. Without its rudder, a boat has no specific direction and veers off course. WIthout goals, I wouldn't have any clear plan for achievement.

These goals also help increase my own awareness. By this I mean that setting goals can help increase my awareness of my own strengths and weaknesses. For example, working toward a goal competition allows me to identify what areas I need to improve to achieve a goal. Goal setting also allows me to identify my own strengths and use them to achieve a goal much quicker or with better quality.

Medium term goals also help me understand specific priorities. What I mean by this is that I may sometimes have difficulty completing tasks because I may not really understand my priorities. Without a set of clear goals, I spend time on things that distract myself from the achievement.

Distractions could include watching television, surfing the web or playing games on the PC. Creating a clear plan of action forces myself to determine my priorities and limit the distraction.

The negative consequences of setting medium-term goals is that it gives pressure and also gives a sense of failure.

Medium term goals can also bring pressure towards myself. Especially if the goals are made by another person. When I am tasked with improving my work performance by a fair amount over the previous year, I might feel the pressure of having to meet that expectation. Even personal goals can create additional pressure towards me. For example, I might have a goal to exercise and I might feel pressure when eating food with high-fat contents on them.

They also give me a sense of failure. By this I mean that, when I don't achieve a goal, I may experience a sense of failure. This failure could prevent myself from setting goals in the future or to work to achieve important milestones.

The way I can improve on this area is by realising that it isn't so bad when I fail to achieve a goal. Instead I should take my time to assess that goal. If the goal was not realistic or the techniques used to achieve it were faulty, then a new goal should take its place. Using this information to adjust goals turns failure into an opportunity for learning.

This can also be applied to the pressure I can get when I get given a goal. If I realise that if I do fail a goal, I realise that it isn’t as bad as i was stressing about. Which helps reduce the amount of pressure I get when doing goals set by myself and by another person.

Setting a Short Term Goal

The positive consequences of setting short-term goals is that setting these short-term goals are a great way of staying motivated, which can be debatable to a certain degree. Setting short-term goals can be very good and helpful because it makes me pay attention to what is about to come up in the short amount of time the goal is set.

The negative consequences of setting short-term goals is that it can sometimes be lots of excitement with very little results. What I mean by this is that trying to reach a small goal within 1-2 weeks usually gets more work done for it that the reward actually pays for.

For example, I may have found a vacancy to a local part-time job, so I set a short-term goal on updating my CV, applying for that job and going to the interview. During that time I can get very overwhelmingly excited by that fact that I am getting a job.

However, I can get so excited that I might get to a point where I don't realise the chance that I do not actually get accepted into the part time job. Then, when it reaches the day whether I

have been hired or not, I will be so overly excited for the letter, that there is a chance that I will be denied a part time job at the workplace, causing a massive drop in confidence.

Furthermore, even if I was accepted within the job and got paid minimum wage due to my current age, it wouldn't still be worth it due to the small amount of money that I am receiving from the part time job.

The way I can improve on this area is by reducing the amount of prospect that I can develop so that it may not exceed the realistic outcome too much to be deluded by the fact there might be no errors.

An evaluation of the SMART target system and its value in achieving your goals

Setting SMART targets

The positive consequences of SMART targets is that they are not vague in nature, the plans are incorporated, it's quicker to identify missed targets, easier to visualise what success looks like, it divides large goals into small attainable ones and that I can use these goals to complete each one at a time instead of all at once.

With SMART targets not being vague helps me in being on track. Due to the fact vague goals doesn't help with focusing on what I want to achieve as much as specific goals. This will also help me to make modifications along the way when I attain my goals.

What I mean with the plans that are incorporated, is that multiple activities can be incorporated into a single goal. For example, when I set a goal (in this instance, I was going to ride a bike), I need the right equipment (helmet, shoulder and knee padding), and something to track my goals (fitness tracker). Hence multiple tasks are coming together.

SMART targets are good at quickly identifying missed targets. What I mean by this is that it is easier to measure what the status of the goal is. Moreover, it is easier to recognise whether I am performing well and whether I need assistance in the long run.

If I have missed a step during the process, it is easier to map and identify which step it was when I have a specific goal. For example, it is easy for sales executives to keep track of what is happening in a week-to-week basis rather than keeping track of sales in an annual basis

SMART goals also make it easier to visualise what success looks like. What I mean by this is that progress is easier to monitor and acts as a gauge to evaluate myself. Hence, it is easier to predict what the results are in the long run and how the results are in the end.

They also help divide large goals into small attainable ones. What I mean by this is that I can try to solve the problem in successive manners. The first step is to divide the set goal into small

attainable goals. This is so I do not exhaust myself by taking up a very large project. Instead, I try to divide the project within myself.

The negative consequences of SMART targets is that it can cause an achievement addiction, spiritual starvation, identity confusion, failing to set goals, idol to setting goals, having a goal setting marathon lifestyle and that it can give me an overly ambitious approach.

SMART targets can cause achievement addiction. What I mean by this is that when I am achieving goals, I periodically might lead myself to an achievement addiction, where I am solely focussed on attaining the goals alone and ignoring other aspects such as health, social relations, and spirituality. This might lead to me being isolated from the rest of the group and in severe cases, may cut off ties that I have with people.

This also causes spiritual starvation. What I mean by this is that there can be an underlying effect on myself while I am constantly achieving goals, a form of spiritual starvation. When I am constantly working under the clock and under pressure, I can ultimately lose the value and the purpose of life.

It can also cause identity confusion, which is where I am being under constant pressure. This can make me question my identity in the society. Which can cause a form of identity crisis within myself. Hence the repercussions cause that I might perform in my free time and ultimately feel sick of it.

It also causes goal setting failure, which is when I repeatedly achieve goals, through goal setting, then don’t achieve a certain foal due to some certain circumstances, it has potential to cause a serious case of feeling depressed. This causes a direct and substantial drop in my own self confidence. Hance it causes myself to think that I am not very useful because I didn’t achieve a goal, when in reality it doesn't mean the end of the world.

Another problem it can create is a goal setting idolatry. This is another factor of this goal setting method, which is just setting up goals just for the sake of goals and I try to engross myself in activities that are not even match with the task itself.

A goal setting marathon lifestyle is also a potential problem this can bring. This is basically constantly working under a constant fast paced and time bound environment, which causes drastic changes in my own lifestyle. This can cause deterioration in my health condition and causes too much stress.
Finally, it can cause an overly ambitious approach. By this I mean that I could set and achieve goals at once. Which, in reality, won’t let me anywhere.

The way I can improve on this area is by reducing the amount of goals that I set for myself. AS you can see in the list of negatives above, they are all due to an overload of set goals which leads to serious consequences as addiction and confusion.

To prevent from all the negatives from happening, I will need to have to make priorities on what I am doing and take singular steps to maintain the final objective. Also, to take sufficient rest in between goals after successive projects.

I also need to realise that If a goal wasn't completed or was impossible to complete, I have to realise that it isn't the end of the world and that I should move on and ignore the fact the goal is no longer achievable, which causes grief and sadness.

An overall review of your experience of making and following your personal development plan

Making a Personal Development Plan

The positive consequences of making a personal development plan is that it gives me self-awareness, a sense of direction, improved focus and effectiveness, more motivation and greater resilience.

With self awareness. A personal development plan helps me understand who I really am, my values, beliefs and the purpose I wish to pursue. True fulfilment can never come from chasing other people's dreams. If i were to achieve lasting happiness, I would need to design my life based on who I am. Then I can chase my own goals and objectives. When I am chasing my own goals, there is a much pleasure to be derived from the journey as there is to be derived from reaching my destination.

With a sense of direction. I have a much clearer view on the things I wish to achieve from life. Decision making becomes a lot easier. Tasks which used to take a great deal of my time, no longer makes it into my to-do list. I realised that they do not not move towards my objectives and therefore aren't really worthy of valuable time.

With improved focus and effectiveness. Since there will be multiple tasks looking for my attention. As my personal development improves, prioritisation becomes much easier. I was much clearer on your objectives and I can quickly identify which task will give me the best result with the resources available to me at the last moment.

WIth more motivation. I would be able to see how easier it is when i see the benefits of taking action. Even when the task ahead is not enjoyable. If I can see a clear benefit, it is more likely that I will be more motivated to take the necessary action. With a strong personal development, I would most likely develop the necessary will.

With greater resilience. I will have the skills and attributes when it comes to the tough times in light and the ability to effectively deal with them. My personal development cannot prevent all bad things from occurring but it will help me deal with them when they do. I will have much greater confidence, resilience, personal and interpersonal skills to cope with any eventuality.

The negative consequences of making a personal development plan is that it can give misdirected planning, it can be time consuming, can have probability in planning and gives a false sense of security.

With misdirected planning. The planning that I might use to serve my individual interest rather than the interest of my future and employment. These attempts can be made to influence the setting of objectives, formulation of plans and programmes to suit my own requirement rather than what will benefit my career.

With time consumption. Planning can be a very time consuming process for me because it involves collection of information, its analysis and interpretation thereof. This entire process takes a lot of time especially where there are a number of alternatives available. Therefore planning is not suitable during emergency or crisis when quick decisions are required.

With a false sense of security. Elaborate planning may create a false sense of security to the effect that everything is taken for granted. For example, I sometimes assume that as long as I work as per plans, it is satisfactory. Therefore I fail to take up timely actions and an opportunity is lost.

The way I can improve on this area is by making sure that the planning should be done way before the actual personal development. For example, instead of doing the planning exactly before the development, I wouldn't need to worry about actually focusing on individual interests that are currently occurring and focus on what the development is for instead.

This will also benefit the worry of time consumption because doing the planning for the personal development before actually doing it will help in me not rushing and stressing myself. This can also reduce the false sense of security and realise that I shouldn't be concerned with getting the development completed, and instead look for why I have made the personal development.

A conclusion of your findings

In conclusion, with me making my development plan I have realised my very own strengths and weaknesses so I can use them accordingly. With my strengths I can use it to focus on goals which benefits the strengths. With my weaknesses, I can make sure that I try my hardest to overcome those weaknesses, if they cannot be overcome then I should focus on not making my goals focus on my weaknesses.

I also realised throughout this development that I should not go overboard with the planning and goals, because the negatives effects that it has on me really outweighs the positives. It could even get rid of the positives in general and leave me in a very stressful and regretful position.

With the plans now revised I can now have much more robust and relevant goals to achieve to help me with my future career and employment.

With my previous planning, I feel that I have been much more organised with my year in the Level 3 IT course. Without a doubt, there has been a few hiccups that prevented me from achieving some of those goals sometimes. However, at the end of they day I still achieved the goals that I have set out.

Overall, I feel that I can achieve all my goals with confidence and realising the harder I work, the more opportunities are given to me and to follow my personal development plan on the way.